

FTC Awards & Advancement — Plain-English Guide

FIRST Tech Challenge · BIOBUZZ (2026–27) · for STEM4U families & coaches

This is an orientation, not the rulebook. Official award criteria live in the **FTC Competition Manual (\$6)**, and how many teams advance (and the exact points) are set by **FIRST Chesapeake** for our events. Award names, sponsors, and numbers can change each season — always confirm against the current manual and FIRST Chesapeake before you rely on them.

The awards — what each one recognizes

Award	What it recognizes	Type
Inspire	The top award — the team that best embodies the whole FTC experience: robot, portfolio, and outreach.	Usually advances first
Think	The engineering journey and how well the Engineering Portfolio documents it.	Judged
Connect	How the team connects with the engineering/STEM community and its strategic plan.	Judged
Innovate	A creative, inventive element of the robot's design.	Judged (sponsored)
Design	Strong industrial / mechanical design and function.	Judged (sponsored)
Motivate	Team spirit, sharing the FIRST message, and being a real team.	Judged
Control	Advanced software — sensors, autonomous, and control.	Judged (sponsored)
Judges' Choice	Something notable the judges want to recognize.	Judged
Winning / Finalist Alliance	On-field match results in the playoffs.	Performance
Dean's List	Outstanding individual student leaders.	Individual

Full criteria & the current sponsored list: [FTC Competition Manual, Section 6](#).

How a team advances (the concept)

FTC runs through **qualifying tournaments → a regional / state championship → (super-regional / FIRST Championship)**, depending on the region. Advancing is **not just winning matches** — each event ranks teams on **advancement points** that blend three things:

- **Judged awards** — Inspire is the highest; award winners advance first.
- **Robot performance** — your qualification ranking from the matches.
- **Alliance selection & playoffs** — being picked and how far you go.

The Inspire Award winner typically advances first, then a mix of other award winners and top performers fill the remaining slots. **The number of advancing spots and the exact point values are set per event by FIRST Chesapeake** — confirm there.

What to prepare (this is where teams win)

- **Engineering Portfolio** — Your documented design journey — judges read it. Start day one and update every meeting.
- **Robot & code** — Build to score, but also to show off design and control for those awards.
- **Robot inspection** — Pass hardware + software inspection before you can play matches.
- **Judging / pit interview** — Every kid should be able to speak to their part of the robot and season.
- **Outreach (Connect / Motivate)** — Plan community engagement early — it's judged, not last-minute.
- **Control Award submission** — If you're going for Control, prepare the submission sheet ahead of the event.

Our season anchors

Kickoff / game reveal: Sat Sep 12, 2026. **Build & iterate:** Sep → Jan. **Regional:** FIRST Chesapeake (~Feb 2027). Confirm all dates on the FIRST Chesapeake site.

Orientation only, prepared for STEM4U — OtterBots · BadgerBots · WolfBots. Official criteria: FTC Competition Manual §6. Advancement specifics: FIRST Chesapeake. STEM4U is not affiliated with FIRST.